Luira Phanit

Resource Identifier: CULT-FEST-001

English Translation: Seed-Sowing Festival

Category: Festival | Subcategory: Agricultural

Village / Region: Hunphun / Ukhrul | Dialect: Ukhrul / Hunphun

Contributor / Source: Tangkhul Community Elders (Traditional Observation (Documented in Hodson 1911, Horam 1977))

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Seasonal Timing / Occasion: January / February (Spring inauguration of agricultural cycle)

Ethnographic Summary & Context:

Prime annual agricultural spring festival celebrated in January/February marking the inauguration of the agricultural cycle. Features ceremonial sod-turning by the Awunga, wrestling (Kaphung), folk dances, and sacred prayers.

Indigenous Tangkhul Text / Chants / Sayings:

"Luira phanitli luisak kashung, iram Hunphunli kapha kachon."

"Awungana shimlut-kaphung sara, luishang kachivali mashak khare."

"Pheichak khangaso, kaphung ngarar, Vareli khorumda ringkaphawui thot."

English Translation & Meaning:

"At the arrival of Luira festival, the seed-sowing season commences in Hunphun."

"The village chief performs the sacred sod-turning ritual before any villager may plant."

"Through festival dances, athletic wrestling, and prayers, the community enters a season of joy."

Procedural Sequence / Observance Steps:

1. Announcement of festival dates by the Hangva (Council of Elders) following lunar observation.
2. Shimlut-Kaphung: Awunga (Chief) turns the first ceremonial clod of earth at dawn and sows sacred seeds.
3. Feast of rice beer (Khor) and community butchering of buffalo and cattle across clans.
4. Athletic competitions: Traditional wrestling (Kaphung), archery, and spear-throwing.
5. Antiphonal dance (Pheichak) and Luira Laa singing performed in full traditional regalia (Haora and Chonkhom).

Ceremonial Participants & Roles:

Awunga (Chief), Hangva (Elders), Clan Heads, Youth Dormitories (Longshim), All Villagers

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